

2.3. Society & Politics

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Code: SSMS-1T3-21

2.3.1. Introduction

The course is considered to be among the essential academic “parent disciplines” of safety and security studies. It combines sociology and political science. Sociology mainly deals with the way people live together and interact with each other in societies. Politics is, as defined by Laswell, about “who gets what, when and how”. Political institutions and politicians decide are also the ones who decide on rules that closely influence safety and security: from setting (safety and security) standards and enforcing compliance, fighting crime and terrorism, surveillance of their citizens to waging war. These processes differ significantly in different countries, often depending on regime type and the ideological and value orientation of the government majority.

In this course, we will first learn sociological perspectives which will locate our own experiences within the larger scale of society characterized by social structure and system. We will also be able to view familiar scenes in a new light, find new meanings in the old and new ways of doing things, and gain understanding and insight of the rapidly globalizing and, at the same time, increasingly diversifying world. We will look into the three main themes of sociology: identity, social order, and stratification. Each of these themes poses an issue with safety and security management in societies. In the end-term module, we will focus on the basics of political science by introducing different types of regimes (democratic, hybrid, authoritarian, totalitarian), their institutions and functioning, regime change, political ideologies, and various factors that influence how politics plays out, such as the concepts of states, nations, identity, social pressures or foreign influence. Relevant examples will be given from either current political events or famous illustrative historical cases.

At the end of the course, students will have attained a new and much broader perspective on current events and the socio-political challenges of the modern world. Practical examples and small activities to highlight certain concepts and how they relate with safety and security issues in our societies will be given and conducted.

2.3.2. Learning goals

- 1) The student identifies major classical and contemporary sociological perspectives, sociological concepts related to identity, social stratification and social order in different international contexts, and how they relate to issues of safety and security.
- 2) The student sociologically interprets his/her/their assessment of certain situations with safety and security issues in mind.
- 3) The student explains the basic tenets and concepts on which states and political systems of democratic and authoritarian regimes are based upon.
- 4) The student distinguishes between different ideologies and types of regimes that exist worldwide.
- 5) The student converts abstract concepts such as democratization, power or authority into concrete, real-world examples and vice versa.

2.3.3. Literature

Mid-term exam:

Macionis, J. J., & Plummer, K. (2012). *Sociology: A global introduction*. England: Pearson Education Ltd. (5th edition)

End-term exam:

McCormick, J., Hague, R., & Harrop, M. (2022). *Comparative government and politics: An introduction* (12th ed.). *Bloomsbury Academic*.

2.3.4. Examination

Examination Mid-Term and End-Term	
Type of examination	Mid-term exam: Individual written exam
	End-term exam: Individual written exam
Material for examination	All course literature and lecture slides
Type of product	Mid-term exam: NA
	End-term exam: NA
Submission protocol	Mid-term exam: NA
	End-term exam: NA
Criteria	Mid-term exam: See (re-sit) exam and answer key
	End-term exam: See (re-sit) exam and answer key
Weighting	Mid-term exam: 50%
	End-term exam: 50%
Assessment procedure	Mid-term exam: See (resit) exam and answer key
	End-term exam: See (resit) exam and answer key
Pass mark	Mid-term exam: A grade of 5.5 or higher (scale 1-10)
	End-term exam: A grade of 5.5 or higher (scale 1-10)
Deadlines and possibilities	Mid-term exam: 1st Opportunity: 13 November 2026 2nd Opportunity: Refer to the schedule for the date, time and location of the second opportunity
	End-term exam: 1st Opportunity: February 2027 2nd Opportunity: Refer to the schedule for the date, time and location of the first and second opportunity

3.2.5. Programme

Session	Subject and contents (lessons)	Format	Preparation
1	Introduction, sociological perspectives and methods	Lecture Dr. Abanes	Ch 1 (pp.4-14; 21-25) Ch 2 (pp.33-52) Ch 4 (pp.106-116)
2	Identity 1: Social construction of everyday life	Lecture Dr. Abanes	Ch 7 Assignment: Application of sociological perspectives
3	Identity 2: Ethnicities and migration	Lecture Dr. Abanes	Ch 11
4	Social order 1: Culture, social movements	Lecture Dr. Abanes	Ch 5 (pp.144-158) Ch 16 (pp.563-567)
5	Social order 2: Control and deviance	Lecture Dr. Abanes	Ch 17
6	Social stratification 1: groups, organizations, network society	Lecture Dr. Abanes	Ch 6
7	Social stratification 2: social division, class	Lecture Dr. Abanes	Ch 8
8	Risk society, cities, and spaces	Lecture Dr. Abanes	Ch 23 (pp.795-797) Ch 24 (p.830; pp.841-849; p.855)
Mid-Term Examination & POP Week			
9	Introduction. Politics, states and nations.	Lecture Dr. Trigo de Sousa	McCormick, Hague & Harrop (2022), Chapter 3
10	Political culture and political ideologies.	Lecture Dr. Trigo de Sousa	McCormick, Hague & Harrop (2022), Chapter 4
11	Democratic rule.	Lecture Dr. Trigo de Sousa	McCormick, Hague & Harrop (2022), Chapter 5
12	Democratic institutions: media & elections	Lecture Dr. Trigo de Sousa	McCormick, Hague & Harrop (2022), Chapters 12 & 14
13	Authoritarian rule	Lecture Dr. Trigo de Sousa	McCormick, Hague & Harrop (2022), Chapter 6
14	Hybrid regimes and the democratization process	Lecture Dr. Trigo de Sousa	TBD
15	Political Economy	Lecture Dr. Trigo de Sousa	McCormick, Hague & Harrop (2022), Chapter 18
16	Recap and preparation for exams.	Lecture Dr. Trigo de Sousa	
End-Term Exam			

3.2.6. Rules & Regulations

Class attendance is not mandatory, but strongly recommended in order for students to successfully complete the course. Guest lectures must be attended. Scheduled dates and deadlines for presentations, workshops, in-class assignments, tests, excursions etc. must be met without fail.